the 'Red Line'. If the PLA were to attempt to storm this line, then we would be forced to fire in self-defence. During the day, the PLA moved additional forces forward, including to Chuti Changla. Now that we were on the Kailash Range, each and every move of the PLA was under our observation. At Rezang La and Rechin La, fourteen ICVs[6] had been moved up and a full squadron of tanks lay in wait at Tara Base. At Mukhpari on the Kailash Range, which overlooked the Spanggur Gap from the South, about a Company strength of the PLA came to the location of 29 PUNJAB, stopping about 300 m short at 1130 hours, and went back after about fifteen minutes when told not to advance any further. Another group of PLA numbering close to 100 troops came to the location of 13 MAHAR at 1400 hours right up to the barbed-wire fencing about 30–35 m away. This group was more aggressive, probably due to their greater numbers, and started shouting for us to take down our sangars and other fortifications, making threatening gestures and even firing two rounds in the air. Col Manish, the Commanding Officer who was present at the location, showed great presence of mind and remained cool-headed throughout this episode while also restraining his own troops. When the PLA tried to cross the barbed wire, we too fired three shots to more telling effect. This immediately put the PLA on the defensive and this group too withdrew.

Towards the afternoon, movement of PLA armour was also observed in the area of their garrison at Moldo. Seeing this, our tanks at Tara Base were also ordered to move up to Rechin La. Armour is traditionally used in the plains and desert terrain, and even if in hilly terrain, only on valley floors that are wide and undulating. It is said that 'tanks hate mountains' and here we were, sending tanks up in high altitude areas, climbing up the steep hillside like mountain goats, at altitudes of over

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